

Operations & Service Handbook 2026

A fictional reference manual for service operations, support, usage policy, private deployment, security, and incident handling.

Demo purpose

This handbook is entirely synthetic. It is designed to test document ingestion, hybrid retrieval, reranking, grounded answers, and evidence display in a public RAG demo.

Names, products, policies, limits, response targets, and procedures in this handbook are fictional and do not describe a real company or service.

What this document contains

- Service tiers and operating scope
- Data retention and legal holds
- Priority definitions and support response targets
- API usage, monthly limits, and excluded requests
- Private deployment production-readiness requirements
- Security and access controls
- P1 incident response and customer notification rules
- Change-window controls and emergency rollback requirements

Service tiers and operating scope

The service uses two commercial operating tiers in this fictional environment: Standard and Enterprise.

Standard is intended for general production workloads with business-hours account management and standard operational safeguards. Enterprise adds 24/7 critical-incident handling, longer retained operational history, private deployment eligibility, and tighter P1 response targets.

Both tiers use the same request authentication model and the same monthly usage accounting rules unless a policy explicitly states an Enterprise exception.

Operational ownership

- Customers own application configuration, user access assignments, and deployment-specific allowlists.
- Northstar Cloud owns platform availability, managed service operations, and the service incident process.
- Private deployments require a named customer production owner before go-live.

Terminology used in this handbook

Term	Meaning
P1	Critical service interruption with material production impact.
Change window	Approved period in which a production change may be executed.
Legal hold	A compliance instruction that suspends deletion for specified records.
Private deployment	Customer-isolated deployment subject to additional pre-production checks.

Data retention and legal hold

Retention applies to operational event records, request logs, and support case history unless a narrower product policy is stated.

Standard plan records are retained for 90 days from creation. Enterprise plan records are retained for 365 days from creation.

At the end of the applicable retention period, records enter the normal deletion process. Routine deletion is automatic and does not require a customer ticket.

Legal hold behavior

A legal hold **suspends deletion for the records named in the hold**, even when the normal Standard or Enterprise retention period has expired. The affected records remain retained until the compliance owner explicitly releases the hold.

Releasing a legal hold does not reset the original retention clock. If the normal retention period already expired while the hold was active, the released records become eligible for deletion in the next deletion cycle.

Retention reference

Plan	Normal retention	During legal hold
Standard	90 days	Deletion suspended for held records
Enterprise	365 days	Deletion suspended for held records

Support priority and response targets

Initial response targets measure the time from accepted case creation to first qualified support response.

For a P1 case, the Standard plan initial response target is 60 minutes. For a P1 case, the Enterprise plan initial response target is 15 minutes.

P1 cases are handled continuously until service impact is stabilized or the incident is reclassified. Enterprise P1 handling is available 24/7; Standard P1 cases created outside the staffed support window are still accepted, but the 60-minute target begins when P1 coverage is active.

Priority definitions

Priority	Example condition	Standard target	Enterprise target
P1	Critical production interruption	60 min	15 min
P2	Major degradation with workaround	4 hours	1 hour
P3	Limited impact or non-urgent defect	1 business day	4 hours

API usage and monthly limits

Monthly usage is measured from accepted customer API requests after authentication and routing.

Requests that pass authentication and reach the customer workload count toward monthly usage, whether the workload returns success or an application-level error.

Excluded requests

The following requests are excluded from both monthly usage and overage calculations: platform health-check requests sent to the documented health endpoint; requests rejected before authentication because the API key is invalid; and Northstar-generated retry traffic marked with the internal retry header.

Customer-generated retries are not excluded. If a customer application retries a valid request, each accepted retry is counted as a separate request.

Overage behavior

When a monthly request allowance is exceeded, accepted customer requests continue to be processed unless the account has an explicit hard cap. Overage billing applies only to counted requests; excluded requests remain excluded after the allowance is exceeded.

Private deployment - pre-production requirements

A private deployment may be prepared in a staging environment before all production-readiness items are complete, but it cannot move to production until every required gate is satisfied.

Required technical gates

- **Security review passed:** the deployment security checklist must be approved with no unresolved critical findings.
- **Network allowlist validated:** production ingress and egress rules must be tested from the customer network.
- **SSO sign-in tested:** at least one production identity must successfully authenticate using the configured enterprise identity provider.
- **Rollback plan approved:** the release owner must document the rollback trigger, responsible operator, and recovery verification step.

Required ownership gates

- **Named production owner:** the customer must designate an accountable production owner before go-live.
- **On-call contact verified:** a reachable operational contact must be recorded for P1 escalation.

A private deployment can move to production only after the security review, network validation, SSO test, rollback approval, production-owner assignment, and on-call contact verification are all complete.

Security and access controls

Access controls are designed to separate identity, administrative privileges, and service-to-service credentials.

Administrative access must use named user identities. Shared administrator accounts are prohibited for production environments.

Private deployment credentials must be stored in the approved secret-management system. Plain-text credentials in deployment scripts, notebooks, or source repositories are not permitted.

Production access review

- Privileged production roles are reviewed every 90 days.
- Departed or transferred users must be removed from privileged roles within one business day of the access-change event.
- Emergency access must be time-limited and documented in the incident or change record that justified it.

The security review referenced in the private-deployment checklist verifies these controls before production approval.

P1 incident response and customer notification

This section defines the operating sequence for critical incidents after P1 severity is confirmed.

When a P1 incident is confirmed, the incident commander records the start time, affected service, customer impact, and current mitigation status. The response team preserves relevant logs and assigns owners for mitigation and customer communications.

Before a customer notification is sent, the incident commander must validate the impact statement, the known scope, and the current mitigation or rollback status. The customer notification must not claim a root cause until the root cause has been verified.

Initial customer notification should identify the affected service, observed impact, current mitigation, and time of the next update. Internal-only evidence, security-sensitive indicators, and unverified causal theories are excluded from the notification.

Notification ownership

The support lead sends the external customer notification after the incident commander confirms that the impact statement, scope, and mitigation status are accurate enough for external communication.

Change windows and emergency rollback

Production changes must remain within an approved window unless the incident commander authorizes an emergency action.

If a P1 incident begins during an active change window, the change owner must pause the active change and preserve the current deployment and application logs. No additional non-mitigation change steps may continue while P1 triage is active.

If the approved rollback trigger is met and rollback is considered safe, the change owner starts the documented rollback procedure. The rollback result is reported to the incident commander before customer-facing status is updated.

For a P1 incident during an active change window, the required sequence before customer notification is: pause the change, preserve relevant logs, execute the approved rollback when its trigger is met and rollback is safe, report the mitigation or rollback status to the incident commander, and then validate impact, scope, and mitigation status before the support lead sends the notification.

A failed rollback does not block notification indefinitely. If rollback fails, the incident commander records the failure as the current mitigation status and validates that status before the support lead communicates it externally.

Quick reference matrix

This page repeats high-value operating facts for faster lookup while preserving the detailed rules in earlier sections.

Topic	Reference fact
Standard retention	90 days
Enterprise retention	365 days
Legal hold	Suspends deletion for held records until release
P1 Standard response	60 minutes
P1 Enterprise response	15 minutes
Usage exclusions	Health checks, pre-auth invalid-key rejects, internal marked retries
Private deployment	All technical and ownership gates must be complete before production
P1 during change	Pause change, preserve logs, rollback if triggered/safe, validate impact/scope/mitigation, then not

End of handbook

This document is synthetic and intentionally structured for retrieval demonstrations. It contains no real customer data, real credentials, or real company policy.